

SmallTalk Coach UI/UX and Motion Research

A practical redesign brief for a professional, warm, habit-forming SwiftUI coaching experience.

The product should feel like a good coach: clear about the next step, specific about what happened, warm when the user struggles, and quietly celebratory when they improve.

9	3	2	21 Jul 2026
apps benchmarked	core priorities	delivery horizons	research snapshot

Prepared from the current SmallTalk Coach SwiftUI source, public App Store listings and screenshots, official design guidance, and open-source repository review.

Executive verdict

Do not build a smaller Duolingo or a prettier Glean. Own the real-conversation learning loop:

Bring a real conversation -> understand what happened -> get one useful response strategy -> practice the weak skill -> improve the next real conversation.

- Make Today emotionally clear: one mission, one progress signal, one primary action.
- Make the coaching result the hero moment: key insight and next move before scores.
- Use motion to explain cause, direction, completion, and progress - not as decoration.

Current product audit

The build is functionally meaningful but still presents like a capable internal tool. Native defaults dominate the visual language, and Home carries too many jobs.

WORKING WELL	LIMITING PROFESSIONALISM
Real curriculum; daily loop; review; streak; reflection; screenshot/text coaching; lesson routing; strong privacy disclosure; resilient errors.	Two overloaded tabs; long sectioned Lists; generic spinners/empty states; form-first coaching; report starts as a dashboard; no shared visual or motion system.

Closest competitors

Gleam	Bite-sized social intelligence lessons, scenarios, quizzes, AI feedback, goals, and milestones. Closest direct competitor.
ADAPT	Warm scenario cards, concise lessons, visible milestones, understandable subscription.
AVOID	Generic charisma positioning and a catalog-first home. SmallTalk Coach has a sharper real-conversation loop.

Skillsta	Ten-minute microlearning, personalized growth journeys, recaps, and AI roleplay.
ADAPT	Explicit time commitment, daily dose, recap as a first-class surface, learn-then-do sequence.
AVOID	Trial pressure before the user experiences meaningful value.

CharmXP	Low-stakes AI rehearsal for interviews, networking, and stressful social situations.
ADAPT	Safe-practice language, scenario previews, confidence as the emotional outcome.
AVOID	Locking all meaningful coaching before trust is earned.

Praktika	Avatar-led, immersive conversation practice with personalities and context.
ADAPT	A consistent coach identity and stronger conversational presence.
AVOID	High-cost avatar spectacle that distracts from real user conversations.

Speeko / Orai	Instant performance reports, metric history, recommended exercises, recording replay.
ADAPT	One insight plus one drill; history that proves progress; evidence linked to behavior.
AVOID	Dashboard overload and scores without plain-language interpretation.

Inspiration benchmarks

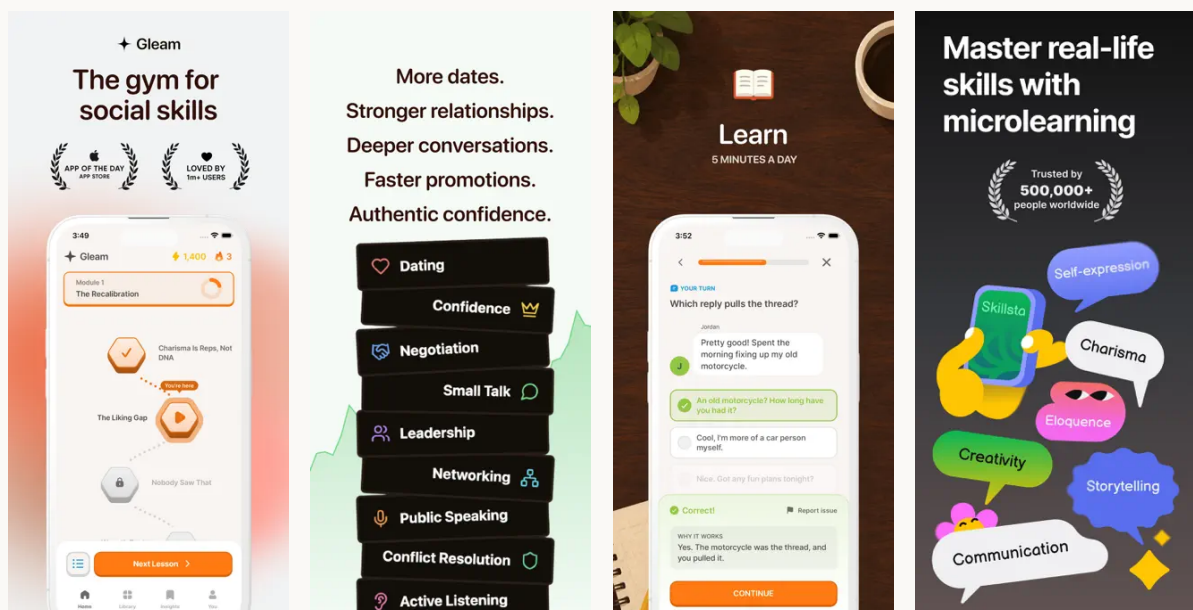
Duolingo	One obvious next lesson, streaks, immediate feedback, path progress, short sessions, expressive state changes.
ADAPT	Single daily CTA, path continuity, low commitment, meaningful micro-celebrations, short active microcopy.
AVOID	Shame-heavy streak pressure, excessive currencies/leagues, childish density, and false right/wrong certainty.

Finch	Gentle companion, tiny tasks, immediate emotional rewards, nonjudgmental habit design.
ADAPT	Warm language and progress without shame.
AVOID	A pet economy that trivializes social anxiety.

Elevate	Personalized daily program, premium visual system, clean metric visualization.
ADAPT	Visual discipline and credible progress presentation.
AVOID	Charts that suggest more scientific precision than the data supports.

Official screenshot references

Selected public App Store marketing screenshots are included as visual references. They are not a recommendation to copy brand assets or layouts.



Glean and Skillsta public App Store gallery samples, retrieved July 21, 2026.

Recommended information architecture

Move from two overloaded tabs to three focused destinations:

- Today: daily mission, streak/progress, due review, and recent coaching follow-up.
- Learn: visual learning path, skill map, completed lessons, and review access.
- Coach: real-conversation analysis, free-draft grading, and history.

Keep Profile and Settings behind the top-right avatar. Every tab should have one job.

Today screen

- Header with greeting, streak, and profile avatar.
- Daily progress strip: 0/1 action or a small minute goal.
- Elevated Daily Mission card with duration, purpose, and one CTA.
- Continue the coaching loop: last insight and recommended next action.
- One due review and a compact weekly skill snapshot.

The first screenful must answer: What should I do, how long will it take, and why does it matter?

Learn, Coach, Report, Lesson

LEARN	Vertical path with completed/current/review/locked nodes. Expand only the current node. Locks explain what unlocks them.
COACH	Start with two mode cards: Help me reply / Review my reply. Then offer Paste text, Import screenshot, or Try an example. Keep trust copy compact and expandable.
REPORT	Key takeaway -> best next move -> examples -> evidence -> skill snapshot -> 60-second practice -> recommended lesson. Scores are secondary.
LESSON	Step 2 of 5 header, paced content, immediate answer feedback, completion summary, real-world challenge, and next action.

Visual direction

Aim for calm confidence: premium, warm, and socially safe - not childish, clinical, or alpha-charisma coded.

COLOR	Warm neutral background; confident indigo; coral/amber warmth; muted emerald success; four stable accessible skill colors.
TYPE	System typography with named roles and full Dynamic Type support. Short titles, generous body leading, no fixed text heights.

SPACE

16-20 pt card padding, consistent 12-16 pt rhythm, selective cards, full-width primary actions, 44x44 minimum targets.

Motion system

TOKEN	BEHAVIOR	USE
Quick	0.16-0.20 s ease-out	Button and chip state
Standard	0.28-0.36 s spring	Card reveal and expansion
Journey	0.45-0.60 s gentle spring	Path advance and report sequence
Celebrate	<= 1.2 s one-shot	Lesson or unit milestone

- Animate the Today progress ring after completion.
- Draw the path connector to a newly unlocked node.
- Morph a selected answer into feedback with matched geometry.
- Preserve spatial continuity from Analyze button to progress to report.
- Use short report-card staggering, copied/saved toast, and restrained milestone confetti.

SwiftUI component plan

Foundation: `AppTheme`, `AppSurface`, `PrimaryActionButton`, `CardStyle`, and `MotionPolicy`.

Product components: DailyMissionCard, DailyProgressRing, StreakBadge, SkillMetricBar, LearningPathNode, CoachModeCard, TrustDisclosureRow, KeyTakeawayCard, ResponseSuggestionCard, LessonProgressHeader, CompletionSummary, SkeletonBlock, and CoachToast.

- Represent visual state with explicit enums, not independent booleans.
- Animate only user-caused or awaited state transitions.
- Keep stable loading geometry to prevent layout jumps.
- Add previews for loading, empty, locked, error, dark mode, reduced motion, and XXL Dynamic Type.

Open-source references

REPOSITORY	DEMONSTRATES	USE
EmergeTools/Pow	State-change and transition effects	Use selectively
open-swiftui-animations	Native progress, loading, springs	Inspiration catalog
SwiftUI-Shimmer	Lightweight shimmer	Good skeleton option
SkeletonView	Mature skeleton patterns	Reference; UIKit-heavy
exyte/PopupView	Toasts and popups	Copied/saved confirmations

exyte/AnimatedTabBar	Animated tab patterns	Reference; native tab safer
ConfettiSwiftUI	One-shot confetti	Unit milestones only
Lottie / Rive	Art-directed or interactive animation	Later, after profiling

Prefer native SwiftUI. Add a dependency only when it saves meaningful maintenance or enables art that cannot be built cleanly in native code.

Accessibility and performance

Accessibility is part of the motion architecture, not a final audit.

- Read accessibilityReduceMotion centrally; replace travel/scale with opacity or immediate state changes.
- Move VoiceOver focus to new feedback/report headings; label metric value and trend.
- Test accessibility Dynamic Type sizes and Differentiate Without Color.
- Keep haptics supplemental and language nonjudgmental.
- Use LazyVStack, avoid continuous blur/particle/shader animation, pause repeating motion off-screen, and profile on an older supported iPhone.

Quick wins: 1-2 days

- Add semantic color, spacing, radius, typography, and motion tokens.
- Create the branded Today header, daily progress, and elevated mission card.
- Add Help me reply / Review my reply mode cards.
- Put key takeaway and next move before coaching scores.
- Add shaped skeletons, useful empty states, press states, copy toast, and success haptics.
- Implement Reduce Motion branches and XXL Dynamic Type checks.

Deeper improvements: 1-2 weeks

- Split navigation into Today, Learn, and Coach.
- Build the visual learning path and step-based lessons.
- Create the narrative report reveal and historical trend cards.
- Add goal-based onboarding and delay notification permission until value is clear.
- Build the post-value paywall and entitlement-aware locked states.
- Add polished unit completion, streak, and milestone motion.
- Run five usability sessions with target users and their own conversation examples.

Priority sequence

P0	Professional clarity	Tokens, Today, Coach mode, report hierarchy, states, accessibility
P1	Delight and retention	Learning path, paced lessons, streak motion, trends, onboarding, paywall
P2	Differentiated personality	Coach identity, art-directed transitions, selective Lottie/Rive, richer scenarios

Measure the redesign

- Onboarding completion and time to first lesson/report.
- Reports that lead to the recommended lesson.
- Lesson completion, next-day return, and 3+ meaningful weekly actions.
- Coaching retry/abandonment and paywall conversion after value exposure.
- Accessibility support issues, launch/scroll/report performance, and crashes.

Selected sources

- Gleam, Skillsta, CharmXP, Praktika, Speeko, Orai, Duolingo, Finch, and Elevate - public US App Store listings.
- Duolingo Blog - new home screen learning path and streak habit design.
- Duolingo Design System - design.duolingo.com.
- Apple Human Interface Guidelines - Motion; SwiftUI accessibilityReduceMotion and accessibility labels.
- GitHub - EmergeTools/Pow, open-swiftui-animations, SwiftUI-Shimmer, SkeletonView, PopupView, AnimatedTabBar, ConfettiSwiftUI, lottie-ios, rive-ios.

Full URLs, version snapshots, repository metadata, and methodology are in the companion Markdown report and source notes.